

Sleep Environment Checklist

Audit your bedroom against the variables sleep research links to sleep quality.

- ☐ **Temperature**
Bedroom 16–19 °C (60–67 °F). Warm the feet, cool the room; body core temperature must fall to start sleep.
- ☐ **Darkness**
Black out window light. Dim overhead lights 1–2 hours before bed; use amber lamps under 30 lux.
- ☐ **Noise**
Aim for a quiet, steady background under about 40 dB. Use steady white or pink noise if street noise is irregular.
- ☐ **Air and humidity**
Ventilate before bed. Keep humidity around 30–50 percent to limit dry airways and dust mites.
- ☐ **Mattress and pillow**
Replace mattresses that sag or cause morning stiffness. A medium-firm surface suits most people.
- ☐ **Screens and devices**
Charge phones outside reach. Remove TVs and work devices from the bedroom.
- ☐ **Bed = sleep**
Use the bed only for sleep. If awake after about 20 minutes, get up until sleepy (stimulus control).
- ☐ **Timing cues**
Fixed wake time daily, morning daylight within an hour, caffeine cutoff about 8 hours before bed.

Score: ____ / 8 items in place

Research Notes

Temperature: Okamoto-Mizuno and Mizuno, Journal of Physiological Anthropology, 2012, reviewed how ambient heat and cold disrupt sleep stages and thermoregulation.

Light: Gooley et al., Journal of Clinical Endocrinology & Metabolism, 2011, found that ordinary room light before bed suppressed melatonin onset in most participants.

Noise: The WHO Environmental Noise Guidelines (2018) recommend night noise below 40 dB Lnight outside bedrooms; Basner et al., The Lancet, 2014, reviewed night-noise effects on sleep and health.

Mattress: Jacobson et al., Applied Ergonomics, 2008, reported reduced discomfort and improved sleep quality after participants moved to a new medium-firm bedding system.

Stimulus control: Bootzin's stimulus control instructions remain a core component of CBT for insomnia.

Limits: Most studies are small or short, and individual needs vary. Persistent insomnia, loud snoring, or breathing pauses warrant a medical evaluation.